

Khan in *Antarmahal*, and now, Amitabh Bachchan and Priety Zinta in *The Last Lear*. *Chokher Bali*, which was completed on a budget of Rs 2.5 crore, made initial business of Rs 3 crore, some of it's profit riding on Rai's name alone. It is this mantra that the new-age directors of Bengal are cashing in on. "The films need to be marketed as plan-to-see movies," says Arijit Dutta, vice-president, Eastern India Motion Pictures Association. Not all critically-acclaimed movies are successful in ig-

niting fire at the box office. Suman Mukhopadhyay's film *Herbert* (released in 2006), based on a mentally retarded character, was a wonderful depiction of north Kolkata life. Although considered a landmark in Bengali cinema by critics, it failed to draw audiences because of poor publicity. Mukhopadhyay's second project, however, was better-off in terms of publicity. A film adapted from Amitav Ghosh's *The Hungry Tide*, the mere announcement of it made national news. "It will be released some-

time in 2010," says Mukhopadhyay.

Good script and proper promotion—both are required for a film to do well and Anjan Dutt, another star in the Bengali film firmament, is doing a bit of both. While working on interesting subjects, he is also roping in big names. His latest venture *BBD* has stars such as Kay Kay Menon, Naseeruddin Shah and Jimmy Shergill. The plot centres around an old area of Kolkata, named after three freedom fighters, which is reinvented through the lives of the 21st century youngsters who believe in "here and now". Distributors in Bengal, however, still prefer to take up movies such as *Minister Fatakeshto*—a sequel to last year's biggest Bengali hit *MLA Fatakeshto*—that hope to ride on the popularity of their predecessors, banking on crass comedy, impossible action, and the gyrations of Bengal's evergreen star Mithun to sail through. "The market for Bengali films is small," says Srikanth Mohta of Shree Venkatesh Films, one of the biggest distributors in the Bengali film industry. That too is changing, however, as the new-age directors are now breaking the barriers of language and making films for a bigger audience. Dutt's *BBD* is in Hindi, while *The Bong Connection* is in English. Aparna Sen's *The Japanese Wife* is in English, Bangla and Japanese, while Ghosh's next *Sunglass* is a Hindi film. "The *Hungry Tide* will be multilingual as well," says Mukhopadhyay.

Low-budget, city-oriented films, too, are doing well. Nitesh Sharma has a perfect model for this. With 37-year-old director Sharon Dutta, Sharma made a horror film *Raat Barota Paanch* (five minutes past midnight) for Rs 27 lakh and got in-film advertising (Eveready, Dollar Undergarments), as in Bollywood, to recover costs. "That way, my producers don't run the risk of losing all their money," Dutta explains. Agrees Sharma, "You get most of your money back from the sales of the film rights itself. Anything that comes out of ticket sales is over and above that."

For now, the youngsters are confident that this will work. "My target audience is between 18 and 30 and I do a film in a way that I make enough money for my next film. That's all," says Dutta. This clearly seems to be the winning formula in ailing Tollywood. ■



SHARON DUTTA, 37

CLAIM TO FAME: *Raat Barota Paanch*, released in 2005. A horror film that had five people spending a night with a ghost. A rare scary Bengali flick after a long time.

BUDGET: Rs 27 lakh **VERDICT:** Costs recovered

BACKGROUND: Also made *Shikar*, a run-and-chase story, that didn't do too well

NITESH SHARMA, 36

CLAIM TO FAME: Produces Bengali movies at impossible budgets. He shoots them in DVD format and avoids making prints to save costs.

BUDGET: Rs 15-30 lakh **VERDICT:** Costs recovered **BACKGROUND:** Executive producer of Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Black*